Pakistan and Afghanistan. Singh was actively trying to bring the US on board on Kashmir, while Vajpayee was simply 'unsure' of these proactive measures.[204] If anything, both Vajpayee and Advani viewed J&K principally as a source of inner-party ideological legitimacy and mass support.[205] Indian narratives emanating from South Asia's nuclearisation, to the India-Pakistan Kargil conflict, and the IC-814 hijack, were sewn together in Kashmir's security predicament and the BJP's 'offensive approach'. On Afghanistan, apart from the bitter realisation of India's limits to influence, the IC-814 incident streamlined India's thinking to develop a positive presence in Pashtun-dominated areas, first in principle and then in practice after the Bonn conference in 2001.

Conclusion

Of the three causal factors that shape India's Afghanistan policy, all three were peculiarly aligned to support the rise of the partisans. The rise of the Taliban with Pakistan's support in 1996 had steeply altered the political balance within Afghanistan in Pakistan's favour. For Indian strategists, this was a reflection of the Pakistan Army's much sought-after 'strategic depth' in Afghanistan. However, unlike its partisan approach towards the Taliban, India remained open to talks with Pakistan throughout the 1990s. Starting with the 1992 Rao doctrine that espoused dialogue with all neighbours, to the 1996 policy approach by PM Gujral that sought to fix the 'tormented relationship between India and Pakistan' through constructive engagement, successive Indian and Pakistani leaders attempted to diffuse tensions.[206] Vajpayee and his Pakistani counterpart Nawaz Sharif signed the Lahore Declaration in February 1999, whereas Sharif's successor, Pakistan's military chief Pervez Musharraf, tried to broker a truce soon after the Kargil conflict in 1999. These moves signified the importance attached to diplomacy amidst tension with Pakistan.[207] Towards the Taliban, however, despite calls for a flexible approach, Indian policy remained staunchly averse.[208]

The Taliban's rise completely fragmented and polarised domestic Afghan politics (much more than during the 1980s) and offered little operational scope for India to strike a balance both within Afghanistan, and between Afghanistan and Pakistan. With the Taliban at the helm the latter power balance became